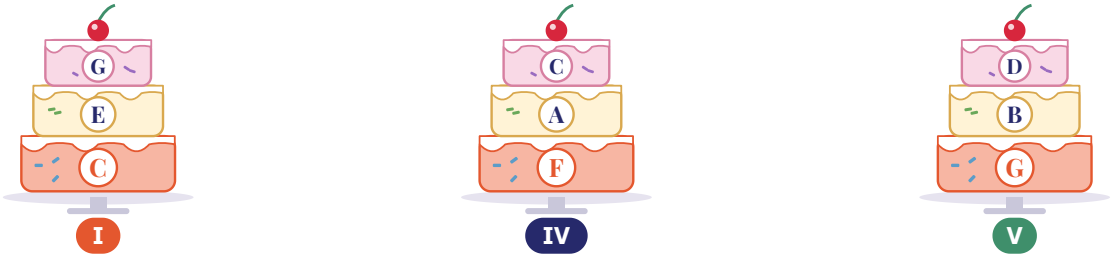
PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 3

Chords under a melody

The melody is the singer; the chords are the band. A good band plays chords that hold the singer's main notes.

THE SECRET

Look at the melody's main notes, then pick the cake that holds them.



C	D	E	F	G	A	B
I, IV	V	I	IV	I, V	IV	V

Which cake holds the tune's main notes?

Every note of C major lives in I, IV or V. C and G live in two: let your ear choose.
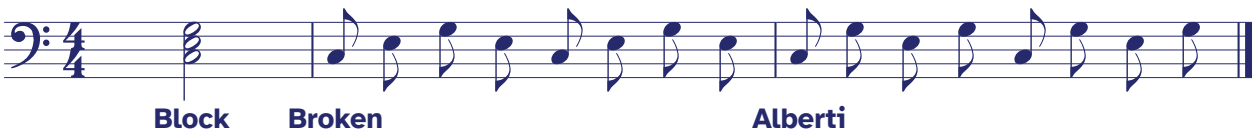
1. Look at the **main notes** of the bar: the long ones, and the ones on beats 1 and 3.
2. Find the cake that holds them: **I, IV or V**.
3. Play that chord in the left hand while the right hand plays the tune.

Twinkle, Twinkle, with its chords



C C G G sit in I (C); A A in IV (F), then G in I; F F in IV, E E in I; D D in V (G), and the last C in I. The chord changes halfway through bars 2, 3 and 4.

Three ways to play the chord in the left hand



Block: all three at once. Broken: one at a time, up and down. Alberti: low, high, middle, high, named after Domenico Alberti, who loved it.

PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Choose the chord: E D C D | E E E

E D C D | E E E

red = beats 1 and 3

1. **Bar 1:** which notes fall on beats 1 and 3 (red)?
2. **Which cake** holds both of them: I, IV or V?
3. **Bar 2:** E E E. Which cake holds E?

E and C both live in **I**, and so does E: both bars take **I** (C). That is the start of Mary Had a Little Lamb.

GAME

Pick the cake
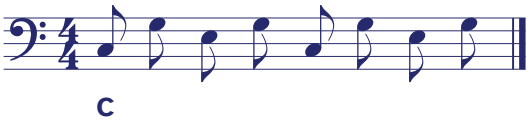
F A F A D B G B G E C E

1 2 3

Each bar is in C major. Which cake holds its notes: I, IV or V?

Answer: 1 IV (F A C) · 2 V (G B D) · 3 I (C E G).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Left hand: C G E G, over and over.

That is the Alberti bass on the C chord. Keep it going while you hum Twinkle, then try it on F (F C A C) and G (G D B D).

YOU KNOW THIS

Mozart, Sonata in C, K. 545: the left hand



The opening left hand is an **Alberti bass**: C G E G is just the C chord, broken into low, high, middle, high; D G F G is G7 (G B D F, without the B). Mozart wrote it an octave higher, starting on middle C.

Try it. Play this left hand alone, then add the famous tune: C, E G, B, C D C.

THINK OF IT Like picking a coat for the weather: when the tune changes, change the chord.

TRAP

- × Choosing a chord for a passing note: use the main notes (strong beats, long notes).
- × Playing the left hand louder than the tune: the melody is the star, the chords are the stage.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 116 · Cadences p. 139

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 21–22 · Online: Library › Chords